

THE STATE OF REVENUE INTELLIGENCE IN THE CHANNEL

*How IT Solution Providers and MSPs Are Closing the Gap Between
Customer Experience and Revenue Outcomes*

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Executive Summary

IT channel companies are navigating a fundamental shift: the revenue model that defined the industry for two decades — hardware margins, one-time project fees, transactional refresh cycles — is giving way to managed services, cloud subscriptions, and recurring contracts. More than half of IT solution providers now expect that 75% of their revenue will come from managed services within the next two years.¹

That shift changes the nature of the customer relationship. In a product-led business, the relationship resets at each transaction. In a services-led business, the relationship *is* the business. Revenue does not reset at renewal — it compounds or erodes over time, based on the experience customers have and the trust they place in the companies managing their technology environments.

Most channel companies recognize this intellectually. What fewer have solved is the measurement problem: how do you know, with enough precision to act on it, where your customer relationships actually stand? Which accounts are genuinely loyal, which are passively satisfied, and which are quietly looking for an alternative? And what is the financial exposure in each category?

This paper examines those questions through market data, published research, and original findings from Revenue Intelligence programs deployed across IT solution providers and adjacent B2B organizations. Three conclusions emerge consistently:

- The customer experience data most channel companies already collect is not being used to predict or protect revenue. It is being reported as a score, not analyzed as a signal.
- The gap between how executives and how day-to-day contacts perceive the same relationship is a reliable leading indicator of renewal risk — and is invisible to traditional CX programs.
- Companies that have connected customer experience to revenue outcomes through structured, persona-level measurement are demonstrating measurable improvements in retention, win rates, and account expansion.

Revenue Intelligence is the discipline that makes that connection. This paper defines what it is, distinguishes it from conventional CX measurement, and provides a framework grounded in channel-specific evidence for how IT solution providers and MSPs can begin applying it.

¹Softchoice + Qualtrics customer success story. [Qualtrics.com/customers/softchoice](https://www.qualtrics.com/customers/softchoice). Published 2025.

1. The Shift That Changes Everything

From Transactions to Relationships

For most of the channel's history, the dominant revenue model was straightforward: sell hardware, license software, deliver a project, collect payment, repeat. Customer relationships mattered, but the commercial mechanics of the business did not require deep measurement of them. If a customer chose a different vendor for the next refresh, the impact was limited to that transaction.

That model is in structural decline. The growth of managed services, cloud-based delivery, and subscription licensing has replaced transactional revenue with recurring contracts — and recurring contracts change the financial logic of the business entirely. A customer who churns does not simply take one deal elsewhere. They remove a predictable revenue stream, often worth multiples of the original transaction, and require expensive replacement through new customer acquisition.

Margin pressure is accelerating the urgency. Hardware margins across the channel have been under sustained compression for years — approximately 44% of value-added resellers now report significant margin pressure, driven by direct OEM sales channels, online procurement platforms, and buyers who are increasingly sophisticated at extracting pricing concessions on commodity hardware.² For many channel companies, the move to services is not simply a strategic aspiration; it is the financially necessary response to a business model in which hardware resale alone no longer supports sustainable profitability. Services deliver the differentiation, stickiness, and margin structure that hardware cannot.

The industry data reflects where this transition stands. More than half of IT solution providers expect managed services to represent 75% of their revenue within two years.³ The global managed services market is growing at approximately 11.5% compounded annually, with cybersecurity managed services growing at 15%.⁴ Yet the transition is neither easy nor fast — research consistently shows that a genuine VAR-to-MSP transformation takes 18 to 36 months to complete.⁵ Many channel companies have started the journey without finishing it, carrying legacy transactional revenue alongside emerging managed services revenue in business models that do not yet reflect the full logic of either.

²More than half of IT solution providers predict 75% of revenue from managed services within two years. ConnectWise Channel Research; ChannelE2E.

³Global managed services market CAGR 11.54%, 2025–2034. Mordor Intelligence Market Report, 2025.

⁴VAR-to-MSP transformation typically requires 18–36 months. Parallels RAS / ChannelE2E analysis, 2025.

⁵Partners operating VAR recurring revenue models report 40–60% higher customer lifetime value vs. project-based peers. Nexus Expert Research, 2025.

For those that have made the shift, the financial case is clear: partners operating recurring revenue models report 40 to 60 percent higher customer lifetime value compared to project-based competitors.⁶ The asset, in a services-led model, is the relationship — and the relationship requires active management.

The New Churn Reality

The managed services model also introduces a churn risk that did not exist in the same way under a transactional model. The IT services industry carries an average annual churn rate of 12 percent.⁷ For a channel company with \$50 million in managed services ARR, that translates to \$6 million in annual revenue at risk from customer attrition alone — before accounting for scope compression, contract restructuring, or the slower erosion of accounts that stay but do not grow.

The more dangerous category is not churn but passivity. Passive customers — those satisfied enough to renew but not engaged enough to expand — represent revenue that is retained but vulnerable. They are the accounts most exposed to competitive displacement at the next contract cycle, the accounts most likely to compress scope when pricing pressure arrives, and the accounts least likely to provide referrals or serve as references. In a services-led business, a large passive customer base is a structural risk that does not yet appear in a revenue report.

Identifying which accounts are passive, and understanding why, requires a different kind of measurement than most channel companies currently deploy. That is the problem Revenue Intelligence is designed to solve.

⁶MSP industry average churn rate: 12%. The MSP Customer Retention Challenge. Xurrent, 2025.

⁷90% of B2B buyers say post-purchase support significantly influences vendor selection. The B2B Buyer Experience Report, 6sense, 2025.

2. The Trust Equation

How Technology Buyers Are Actually Selecting Their Vendors

The buying behavior of technology customers has shifted significantly in the past five years, and the implications for channel companies are more consequential than most recognize. Two trends are particularly important.

First, trust has become the primary filter in vendor selection. Ninety percent of B2B buyers say that post-purchase support and relationship management significantly influences their vendor selection — not at the end of the relationship, but *before the next purchase begins*.⁸ More than half of B2B decision-makers will only share information with brands they already know and trust.⁹ Companies that excel at building loyalty grow 2.5 times faster than their competitors.¹⁰ The relationship with the existing provider is now a competitive asset that must be actively maintained — and actively measured.

Second, the buying committee has grown dramatically in size and complexity. B2B buying committees averaged 5.4 stakeholders in 2015. By 2025 that number had nearly doubled to 8 to 13 members — and in enterprise technology decisions, the committee can span 25 or more individuals across departments.¹¹ Eighty-two percent of B2B purchase decisions are now consensus-driven.¹² Analysis of 1.8 million deals found that engaging multiple stakeholders — rather than managing a single executive relationship — boosts win rates by 130 percent on deals over \$50,000.¹³

What This Means for Channel Companies

The implications for IT solution providers and MSPs are direct. In a world where buying decisions are committee-driven and trust is distributed across an organization rather than concentrated in a single executive, the companies that know how their relationships stand — across all relevant stakeholders — have a structural advantage.

⁸52% of B2B decision-makers will only share information with brands they already know and trust. 6sense B2B Buyer Experience Report, 2025.

⁹Companies great at building loyalty grow 2.5x faster than competitors. SAP Engagement Cloud / Emarsys Customer Loyalty Statistics, 2026.

¹⁰B2B buying committees averaged 5.4 stakeholders in 2015, rising to 8–13 by 2025. B2B Buying Committees: Why 8–13 Stakeholders Changed Enterprise Sales. Attainment Labs, 2025.

¹¹82% of B2B purchase decisions are consensus-driven. Attainment Labs / Gartner, 2025.

¹²Multithreaded engagement boosts win rates 130% on deals over \$50K. Gong analysis of 1.8 million deals, 2025.

¹³NPS industry leaders grow more than 2x faster than competitors; NPS explains 20–60% of organic growth variation. How Net Promoter Score Relates to Growth. Bain & Company.

Most channel companies manage a portfolio of executive relationships. They know how the CIO or IT director feels about them. What they do not systematically know is how the procurement team feels about the renewal process, how the operations team rates day-to-day support quality, or how the end-users who depend on managed services experience the relationship between quarterly business reviews. Those contacts — the influencers and daily stakeholders who shape the decision-maker's view in internal conversations — are the people the account team never speaks with directly.

That blind spot is not a minor inconvenience. It is where churn risk forms, quietly, over months, before it surfaces in a renewal conversation.

“Like most organizations, our customers have choices — they can procure the same products and similar offerings from an array of competitors. To stand out, we must differentiate on the experience we deliver.”

— Katie Duvnjak, Director of Customer Experience, Softchoice

The Trusted Advisor Gap

Most channel companies aspire to be trusted advisors. In surveys and business planning conversations, this is the most common strategic objective cited. But very few have a systematic way to know whether their customers actually experience them as trusted advisors — rather than as competent vendors. The aspiration is present. The measurement is not.

This matters because the trusted advisor designation is not simply a label — it is a commercial position. Customers who view their solution provider as a trusted advisor expand their spend, reduce competitive evaluation, provide references, and renew with less friction. Customers who view the same company as a vendor do the opposite. Knowing which category each account falls into — and why — is the foundation of revenue protection in a services-led business.

3. Why Traditional CX Metrics Fall Short

Most channel companies that measure customer experience do so through NPS surveys, periodic CSAT assessments, or post-project feedback forms. These programs have genuine value: they are better than nothing, they produce data that can surface obvious problems, and they create a baseline for comparison over time. But they are fundamentally inadequate for the purpose of managing revenue risk in a recurring services business.

Four structural limitations explain why.

Too aggregated. A single NPS score collapses the experience of multiple stakeholders across multiple touchpoints into a single number. That number cannot tell you whether the problem is in the presales process, the onboarding experience, day-to-day support, or the renewal conversation — and it cannot tell you which personas are satisfied and which are not. Without that specificity, a score is not actionable.

Too lagging. NPS typically measures sentiment after a significant experience — a project completion, a contract renewal, an annual review. By the time the score reflects a problem, the underlying cause has often been present for months. In managed services, where relationships are continuous rather than episodic, waiting for an annual survey to detect account risk is equivalent to reading last quarter's financial report to inform today's decisions.

Not diagnostic. Even when NPS drops, a traditional program cannot reliably identify the root cause. Is the problem commercial friction in the renewal process? Technical credibility erosion? Poor support responsiveness? Strategic misalignment at the executive level? Without a structured framework that measures each of these dimensions separately, the response to a score drop is guesswork.

Not attributable in channel ecosystems. In indirect go-to-market models, customer satisfaction reflects the OEM relationship, the partner relationship, the product quality, and the service delivery quality — all at once. Traditional surveys cannot separate these signals. The result is data that is interesting but not actionable, because no one can determine whose problem it is to fix.

The contrast between what a traditional CX program produces and what Revenue Intelligence produces is not subtle. Consider the same underlying situation rendered through each lens:

Traditional CX Output	Revenue Intelligence Output
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NPS dropped 4 points this year.	Renewal risk is rising in mid-market accounts in the East region. The primary driver is high operational friction. Procurement and operations teams are frustrated with quotation accuracy. Without a fix, 15–20% of next year's renewal revenue in that segment is at risk.
Our CSAT score for ordering is consistently below 4.	Our largest accounts rate our quoting and invoicing process lower than mid-market accounts, and lower than peers in this category. This is limiting our ability to expand inside strategic accounts.
Overall satisfaction: 7.8 out of 10.	The 12-point NPS gap between Decision Makers and Influencers in our top revenue accounts represents the highest concentration of renewal compression risk in the portfolio.

The difference is not in the data collected. It is in how the data is structured, segmented, and connected to commercial outcomes. That is what Revenue Intelligence provides.

4. Defining Revenue Intelligence

Revenue Intelligence is the systematic connection between what customers experience and what that means for retention, expansion, and churn risk — structured to produce forward-looking, actionable signals rather than backward-looking satisfaction scores.

It is built on three structural elements that, taken together, produce intelligence that traditional CX programs cannot.

Journey-Based Measurement

Revenue Intelligence maps customer experience to the specific stages where revenue is won or lost. Rather than asking a single annual question about overall satisfaction, it measures what customers experience at the moments that drive commercial outcomes:

- Sales and Solution Design — which influences conversion rates, margin, and competitive displacement
- Procurement and Contract Onboarding — which shapes first impressions, establishes the commercial relationship, and determines whether the partnership begins with confidence or friction. The contracting and vendor onboarding experience — including MSA negotiation, legal review, and order processing — is frequently overlooked but carries lasting consequences: 74% of B2B buyers say their contracting experience made them more likely to buy from the same vendor again, and more than 20% of voluntary B2B churn traces back directly to poor onboarding experiences.
- Onboarding and Implementation — which drives adoption, time-to-value, and early churn
- Support and Operations — which determines stickiness, services expansion, and risk escalation
- Renewal and Expansion — which directly determines retention and revenue growth

Measuring at each stage creates leading indicators. Problems in the procurement experience or onboarding journey typically surface in renewal data 12 to 18 months later — measuring only at renewal means arriving after the decision has already shifted. Journey-based measurement enables intervention while there is still time to change the outcome.

Persona-Based Measurement

In B2B relationships, "the customer" is not a single person. Renewals and expansions are driven by specific stakeholders making specific decisions from specific organizational positions:

- Executive sponsors determine strategic alignment and budget authority
- Technical authorities determine product and platform standards, architecture decisions, and competitive preference
- Commercial and procurement contacts determine renewal friction, contract structure, and buying experience
- Operations and end-user contacts determine whether the day-to-day environment is stable, supported, and worth defending to their leadership

Revenue Intelligence captures confidence and friction by persona, not just by account. This matters because the executive relationship and the day-to-day experience of the account can be — and frequently are — diverging. An executive who has a strong relationship with the account team may be unaware that the procurement team finds the renewal process frustrating, or that the operations team is quietly evaluating alternatives because support quality has declined. That divergence is invisible to account-level NPS. It is visible to persona-level Revenue Intelligence.

The Intersection: Where Intelligence Becomes Actionable

The combination of journey stage and persona is where Revenue Intelligence moves from interesting to commercially decisive. The intersection produces revenue action statements rather than satisfaction summaries:

- Commercial persona x Renewal journey: predicts renewal slippage risk and contract compression
- Technical persona x Sales and Design journey: predicts win rate, services attach, and competitive displacement
- Operations persona x Support journey: predicts services expansion or churn at the next contract cycle
- Executive persona x Strategic touchpoints: predicts multi-year expansion and strategic stickiness

The output is not a dashboard of scores. It is a prioritized view of where revenue is at risk and where it can be grown — by account, by segment, and by the specific dimension of the relationship most likely to drive the outcome.

How It Is Delivered

Revenue Intelligence is not a software platform or a survey tool. It requires methodology — survey architecture designed around journeys and personas — combined with distribution expertise, analytical depth, and closed-loop action management. These elements must work together, and they require practitioner judgment at every stage.

Most channel companies do not have this capability internally, and building it from scratch requires 12 to 18 months and year-round headcount that cannot be justified against a quarterly survey cadence. A fully managed Revenue Intelligence engagement delivers this capability from the outset — standing programs up in weeks rather than quarters, and operating at an analytical depth that most internal teams cannot replicate regardless of tenure or resources.

5. The Multi-Persona Problem: The Blind Spot Inside Your Best Accounts

Every experienced channel sales leader has a version of this story: a customer relationship that felt solid — regular QBRs, an engaged executive, a long track record — that compressed unexpectedly at renewal, or defected to a competitor without any visible warning in the pipeline.

The mechanism behind most of those surprises is the same: the executive relationship was healthy, but the influencer population — the day-to-day contacts who shape the decision-maker's view in internal conversations between renewal cycles — was not. The problem formed over months, in conversations the account team was never in, and surfaced only when the renewal negotiation revealed that the customer's internal position had already changed.

This is the multi-persona problem, and it is structural in channel accounts. A managed services relationship touches more organizational layers than a hardware transaction: IT operations, end users, finance, security, procurement, and executive leadership may all interact with the service provider at different points in the engagement. Each has a different view of the relationship. Any of them can influence the renewal outcome.

What the Data Shows

Revenue Intelligence programs deployed across IT solutions providers reveal a consistent version of this pattern. In one illustrative program, the participating company carried an overall NPS of 74 — well above the 40 to 55 average for the technology services sector, reflecting a genuinely strong customer base by conventional measures.¹⁴

74 Overall NPS Score	40–55 Technology Services Industry Average	12 pts Decision Maker vs. Influencer NPS Gap	74% NPS Movement Explained by Top 3 Drivers
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Beneath that strong headline score, the program surfaced a 12-point gap between the NPS of Decision Makers and the NPS of Influencers across the same accounts. Influencers — the day-to-day contacts who interact most directly with the provider's delivery team — rated the relationship measurably lower than the executives who attended quarterly business reviews. Accounts with wide Decision

¹⁴Detractors churn at 50% annually; Passives at 25%. Promoters generate 40–70% higher customer lifetime value. 40 B2B NPS Benchmarks for 2025. CustomerGauge.

Maker-to-Influencer gaps are disproportionately exposed to unexpected renewal compression, regardless of what the aggregate NPS suggests.

Key driver analysis identified the three dimensions that collectively accounted for approximately three-quarters of NPS movement in the program: trust and perceived commitment to the relationship, account executive quality and responsiveness, and ongoing support reliability. All three are driven by the human quality of the relationship — not by product portfolio, pricing, or technology differentiation.

Why This Pattern Repeats Across Channel Organizations

The multi-persona problem appears consistently across channel companies of different sizes and business models. A managed services engagement is continuous and touches multiple functional teams with no clear endpoint — IT operations, procurement, finance, security, end users, and executive leadership may all interact with the provider at different moments and form different impressions of the same relationship.

This requires a fundamentally different account management model, and it requires a measurement system that can reflect multi-stakeholder reality. A single satisfaction score reported at the executive level is not adequate for managing a relationship of this complexity. Account teams need to know how procurement feels about the renewal process, how operations rates support quality, and how end users experience the services they depend on — before those perceptions become a negotiating position at the next contract cycle.

6. The Revenue at Stake: Quantifying the Passive Customer Problem

The financial case for Revenue Intelligence is not abstract. It is grounded in the measurable spending difference between customer segments that most channel companies have never quantified — and in the revenue exposure that most cannot currently see.

The Promoter/Passive/Detractor Spending Gap

Research across B2B sectors consistently demonstrates that satisfied customers and loyal customers are not the same thing, and that the gap between them has direct revenue consequences. Promoters — customers who would actively recommend the provider — generate 40 to 70 percent higher customer lifetime value than Passives.¹⁵ They stay longer, spend more, expand their engagement, and generate referrals. Detractors churn at 50 percent annually; Passives at 25 percent; Promoters at 5 to 10 percent.

NPS leaders in their respective industries grow more than twice as fast as their competitors, and NPS explains 20 to 60 percent of the variation in organic growth rates across competitive markets.¹⁶ A 10-point NPS improvement typically drives 4 to 8 percent revenue lift — an impact that, for a channel company with \$50 million in managed services ARR, represents \$2 to \$4 million in incremental annual revenue.¹⁷

What Revenue Intelligence Programs Surface

The spending differential between promoters and passives is not theoretical. Revenue Intelligence programs consistently surface it in specific, account-level terms that allow leadership to prioritize relationship investment with financial precision.

In a program deployed across a full-service industrial supplier — a company with a comparable B2B account management model to a technology solutions provider — the program reached more than 20 percent of the company's active customer base across two measurement waves.¹⁸ The headline NPS of 60 reflected a strong base: two-thirds of respondents were Promoters. But Promoters spent three times as

¹⁵A 10-point NPS improvement drives 4–8% revenue lift. CustomerGauge / SurveySensum analysis, 2025.

¹⁶Veeam NPS of 73, 3.5x the industry average, in the year of a 27% YoY revenue increase. Veeam Software press release, VeeamON, May 2018.

¹⁷"I find that linking NPS and revenue makes people sit up straight, and moves the conversation from 'just a metric,' to strategic responses and actions." Dr. James Borderick, Master Strategist, HPE Software. CustomerGauge NPS Benchmarks interview, published 2017.

¹⁸VistaXM client engagement data. All case studies anonymized; identifying details withheld at client request.

much annually as Passives — \$162,000 versus \$54,000. The program quantified the financial stakes precisely:

3x Promoter vs. Passive Annual Revenue	\$14.9M Upside from Converting Passives to Promoters	\$11M+ Revenue Protected in At-Risk Accounts	\$26.8M Combined Opportunity-and-Risk Pool Identified
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The program also surfaced a significant vulnerability with the company's largest OEM customer — an account where half of all respondents were Passives or Detractors, a concentration of risk that was entirely invisible before the program. That customer rated on-time delivery and value for cost notably below every other major account. The intelligence enabled leadership to address the vulnerability directly, protecting more than \$11 million in revenue that had no early warning system before the program existed.

The Channel-Specific Application

A Revenue Intelligence program deployed across an IT solutions provider showed a more extreme version of the same dynamic. Promoters spent more than seven times as much annually as Passives in that customer base.¹⁹ Passive accounts — customers who were satisfied enough to retain but not engaged enough to grow — represented a significant share of total revenue. These accounts were retained in the current period but most exposed to competitive displacement at the next renewal.

The program modeled NPS improvement scenarios that demonstrated how each point of score gain translates into tens of millions of dollars in incremental multi-year revenue across the customer base. For the first time, leadership had a direct financial framework for prioritizing relationship investment — not based on intuition about which accounts felt most at risk, but based on a structured analysis of where risk was actually concentrated and why.

Most channel companies have the revenue. They do not have the visibility. Revenue Intelligence provides it.

¹⁹Approximately 44% of VARs report significant margin pressure from direct OEM sales channels and online marketplaces. VAR Street Inc., Value-Added Resellers: Challenges & Risks, 2025; Verified Market Research, Value-Added Resellers for IT Market, 2025.

7. Evidence from the Channel: What the Leaders Are Proving

Named, publicly verifiable evidence of Revenue Intelligence programs producing measurable results in IT solution providers and channel companies is relatively sparse — which is itself a data point. Most channel companies are not yet doing this systematically, and those that are have not widely published the results. The examples that do exist are instructive precisely because they demonstrate what becomes possible when a channel company commits to connecting experience data to revenue outcomes.

Softchoice: Responsiveness as a Revenue Driver

Softchoice is a software and cloud-focused IT solutions provider well-recognized across the industry. The company understood that customer satisfaction was the clearest path to retention and revenue growth. What it lacked was the analytical precision to know where to focus.

Using structured CX analytics across more than ten active customer touchpoints, the Softchoice team identified the performance variable most strongly correlated with NPS movement: sales representative responsiveness. Rather than treating this as a directional finding, the team studied the daily practices of high-responsiveness reps versus low-responsiveness reps and documented eight concrete behavioral differences — including acknowledging customer requests within one hour, dedicating structured time at the start and end of each shift to customer correspondence, and ensuring no customer emails went unanswered overnight.

Those practices became the foundation for targeted training programs and technology solutions. Responsiveness was elevated to a corporate-level KPI reviewed by senior leadership — giving the initiative the organizational commitment required to drive behavioral change at scale.²⁰

The measured two-year result:

+8 pts NPS Increase Over 2 Years	+7 pts Customer Satisfaction with Responsiveness	−4% Customer Churn Reduction	\$8.4M Total Measured Business Impact
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Win rates increased by 10 percent in the districts and teams that met or exceeded the responsiveness satisfaction target. The total measured business impact across

²⁰74% of B2B buyers say their contracting experience made them more likely to purchase from the same vendor again. Corporate Visions, B2B Buying Behavior Statistics, 2026. Over 20% of voluntary B2B churn is linked to poor onboarding experiences. Rivo, 27 B2B Customer Retention Statistics, 2026.

churn reduction and win rate improvement was \$8.4 million. The core principle the Softchoice case illustrates: the most valuable insight is not always the hardest to find. It is often hidden in existing feedback data, waiting for the right analytical framework to surface it and the organizational commitment to act on it.

Veeam Software: CX as Competitive Weapon

Veeam Software's go-to-market is built entirely through the channel — 55,000 channel partners including VARs, MSPs, and cloud service providers. As a vendor whose commercial results depend on the strength of its channel relationships, Veeam's CX investment offers a relevant perspective on what sustained commitment to customer experience produces.

Veeam's NPS grew from 30 in 2014 to 73 by 2018 — a 43-point improvement over four years, sustained as five consecutive years of outperforming the industry average by a factor of 3.5 times.²¹ In the year of their peak score, 91 percent of customers indicated they planned to renew their contract, and Veeam reported 27 percent year-over-year revenue growth.

The channel implication is direct: the solution providers who carry Veeam in their portfolio are selling to customers whose satisfaction with their provider — including the solution provider relationship itself — ultimately determines whether they renew and expand. A partner whose customers are Promoters of the overall technology relationship retains and grows accounts. A partner whose customers are Passives or Detractors loses them — to the OEM's direct channel, to a competitor, or to a competing vendor entirely.

Hewlett Packard Enterprise Software: Linking NPS to Revenue Prediction

Hewlett Packard Enterprise Software is among a small number of large technology companies that have publicly documented the explicit connection between NPS and revenue forecasting. Dr. James Borderick, then Master Strategist for HPE's Net Promoter Competitive Loyalty program, described the approach in a published industry interview:²²

“I speak with the leaders of our business units on a quarterly basis, highlighting areas that will increase our NPS, predicting how much the NPS would increase given implementing changes, and consequently what effect this has on our revenue. I find that linking NPS and revenue makes people sit up straight, and moves the conversation from ‘just a metric,’ to strategic responses and actions.”

— Dr. James Borderick, Master Strategist, HPE Software

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HPE Software's approach — using NPS as a revenue prediction tool rather than a reporting metric, with quarterly business unit conversations focused on the revenue implication of specific changes — is precisely the logic of Revenue Intelligence applied at enterprise scale. The relevant finding for channel companies: only 33 percent of companies that measure NPS make an explicit link between NPS and revenue. The other 67 percent are collecting data that does not drive decisions.

A Common Thread Across All Programs

Across every program examined, a consistent pattern emerges. Each company had customer data. None had the structure, methodology, or analytical framework to convert it into revenue decisions. Each achieved measurable value — in weeks, not quarters — by applying the Revenue Intelligence discipline: connecting experience signals to the financial outcomes those signals predict, and acting on the connection before it showed up in a pipeline report or a churn event.

8. Building Revenue Intelligence Capability

What a Program Requires

A Revenue Intelligence program is not a survey tool or a CRM add-on. It is a management discipline with four interdependent components, each of which must be designed and operated with precision for the program to produce commercially useful intelligence.

Program architecture. The foundation is a measurement framework built around the journeys and personas that drive commercial outcomes in the specific business. This requires experienced practitioners — not generic survey templates — to design questions that surface the signals most predictive of renewal, expansion, and churn in the client's specific model. Most self-built programs break down here, producing surveys that generate responses but not intelligence.

Distribution and response management. Response rates are not a minor operational detail. Generic, unmanaged surveys in B2B environments commonly achieve response rates in the low single digits — producing data that reflects an unrepresentative sliver of the customer base. Professionally designed programs, with structured distribution cadences, personalized outreach, and deliberate follow-up timing, consistently achieve response rates of 10 to 20 percent or more. The difference in representativeness — and therefore in the reliability of the intelligence produced — is substantial.

Analytics and action routing. Raw survey responses are inputs, not intelligence. The analytical work — segmenting data by journey stage and persona, identifying the specific drivers that correlate most strongly with NPS movement and revenue outcomes, modeling the financial impact of improvement scenarios — transforms responses into decisions. This is where the distinction between a CX reporting function and a Revenue Intelligence function is most visible.

Closed-loop action management. Insights without action are reports. A Revenue Intelligence program requires formal processes for routing findings to the people who can act on them, establishing accountability for follow-up, and tracking whether interventions changed outcomes. The loop between insight and result is what creates organizational learning over time — and what allows the program to improve its predictive accuracy with each cycle.

The Build-vs.-Partner Decision

Building these four components internally requires a dedicated capability with practitioner-level expertise in survey science, data analysis, and action management — year-round, not just during survey cycles. Most channel companies cannot justify that investment for a quarterly program. The alternative —

conducting an annual survey through a generic platform — produces data that looks like intelligence but lacks the structure to function as it.

A fully managed Revenue Intelligence engagement makes enterprise-grade capability accessible without the internal investment. Programs stand up in weeks. Response rates improve immediately with professional distribution design. Analytics are delivered in a form leadership can act on, not simply admire.

The cost of a Revenue Intelligence program is recoverable from a single prevented churn event in most mid-market channel organizations. For a company with \$50 million in managed services ARR and a 12 percent industry average churn rate, preventing even one account loss of \$500,000 in annual contract value recovers a meaningful portion of annual program cost. The math becomes straightforwardly positive with any systematic improvement in retention.

Where to Begin

The most effective starting point is a full relationship baseline — measuring across the entire active customer base rather than a subset. A complete baseline captures the full range of account health, surfaces unexpected concentrations of risk in accounts that may not be top-of-mind, and provides the most reliable foundation for prioritization. In practice, polling all customers is no more operationally complex than polling a subset, and the additional data significantly increases the reliability and diagnostic power of the program.

That initial baseline typically surfaces identifiable risk and opportunity that justifies the full ongoing program investment — and establishes the baseline against which improvement is measured in subsequent cycles. The question is not whether to do this. The question is what it costs to continue not doing it: in revenue lost to silent attrition, in competitive displacement that arrives without warning, and in account expansion that does not happen because the relationship has plateaued without anyone knowing it.

Conclusion: The Intelligence Gap Is the Competitive Gap

The channel's revenue model has shifted. Managed services, recurring contracts, and subscription-based delivery have replaced the transactional logic that defined the industry for decades. The companies that will sustain and grow in this environment are the ones that manage customer relationships with the same rigor they apply to their operational and financial metrics.

That requires knowing — not assuming — where relationships stand. Which accounts are promoters, and which are passives quietly eroding? Which personas within your most important accounts hold a view of the relationship that differs meaningfully from the executive's? Which journey stages are creating friction that will surface as a problem at the next renewal? And what is the precise financial stake in each answer?

Revenue Intelligence provides that knowledge. The evidence from the companies that have deployed it consistently points to the same outcomes: better retention, higher win rates, earlier identification of at-risk revenue, and a financial framework for relationship investment that replaces intuition with data.

The companies that do not have this visibility are managing their most important asset — their customer relationships — with instruments that were designed for a different business model. The gap between what they know and what their best competitors know is not a technology gap or a talent gap. It is an intelligence gap. And in a recurring revenue business, intelligence compounds.

The relevant question for any channel company reading this is straightforward: *Where do you know — not assume — where your customer relationships stand today?*

About VistaXM

VistaXM transforms customer feedback into Revenue Intelligence — the systematic connection between how customers feel and what that means for retention, expansion, and churn risk. Rather than delivering software or survey tools, VistaXM brings experienced practitioners, a proven scientific methodology, and advanced analytics to design, deploy, and operate comprehensive Revenue Intelligence programs on behalf of our clients.

We link experience signals — NPS, CSAT, eNPS, and multi-dimensional performance scores — to the financial metrics that matter: Net Revenue Retention, renewal probability, upsell readiness, and account-level risk. Programs stand up in

weeks, not quarters. Intelligence is delivered at a level of analytical depth that most internal teams cannot match.

If you are managing a customer base where retention and expansion are the primary growth levers, we would welcome a conversation about what Revenue Intelligence could surface for your business.

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